OPTIONAL RULES · D&D 2024

Playing a Dishonored-Style Game

A Dishonored-style game is about planning: a small party studies a guarded space, picks a route, and takes it apart one quiet guard at a time, until something goes wrong.

V0.1 PLAYTEST GM GUIDANCE INSPIRED BY DISHONORED

The Map

- **Show the players a map.** They need to see the mission area to track guard movements and lines of sight and plan their routes.
- **Not everything is marked.** Secret rooms, hidden passages, air ducts, and rooftop routes can stay off the map until the players find them through exploration, scouting, Void Sight, or Foresight.
- **Enemies appear only when spotted.** A guard goes on the map once a character sees them. From then on, track their movement and patrol route as the players observe it.

- **Facing matters.** Mark which way each spotted guard is facing, with an arrow on their token or a small notch. A guard sees only in front of them, roughly the half of the map their arrow points toward, so a character who approaches from behind can stay hidden right up to the takedown. Turn a guard's facing when their patrol turns, when they hear a noise, or at the end of each mission turn if they're standing watch.

Mission Turns

Outside combat, time passes in **mission turns**, like the dungeon turns of older editions. Each turn lasts 1 minute or 5 minutes:

- **1-minute turns** for tense stretches: guards are nearby, or the party is mid-infiltration.
- **5-minute turns** for quiet stretches: moving through empty areas, waiting out a patrol, or searching an office.

During a turn, each character does one significant thing, such as crossing an area, picking a lock, scouting a room, hiding a body, or waiting in place.

At the end of each turn, the world moves:

- **Patrols advance.** Each patrolling guard ends the turn at the other end of their patrol route.
- **NPCs move.** Servants, civilians, and targets follow their own schedules.
- **The mission advances.** Events already in motion move forward, such as a shift change, a party winding down, a target heading for the vault, or a ritual nearing completion. These should change the shape of the mission in a meaningful way.

Write a timeline. Before play, jot down a short list of what happens and when, such as "Turn 4: shift change at the gate" and "Turn 10: the target leaves for the docks." Waiting then has a real cost.

When the party is discovered, or a takedown needs blow-by-blow resolution, switch to normal 6-second combat rounds.

Party and Encounters

- **Small party.** This style works best with 1 to 3 players.

- **Few enemies in any one place.** Mostly singles and pairs, spread across the map, rather than big groups in one room.
- **Room for quiet takedowns.** Give the players chances to isolate guards and remove them individually and quietly. Their first interaction with a guard ideally shouldn't alert everyone.

Takedowns

In this style, an ordinary guard dies to one stealthy strike but can hold their own in an open fight. The Takedown rule makes that happen.

Who can be taken down. Any creature without the Resilient tag that's **unaware** of you. An unaware creature hasn't noticed you, isn't searching, and isn't alerted.

How. Make a single-target attack against it while you're hidden or it can't see you.

- **Melee:** from behind or from above, the takedown is automatic.
- **Ranged:** roll to hit with Advantage, since you're unseen. On a miss, the target is alerted.

Result. The creature drops instantly, dead or unconscious as you choose. Area effects, like Fireball or a Frag Grenade, never cause takedowns; they deal normal damage.

Chokes are slower. A nonlethal melee takedown Restrains the creature until the start of your next turn, then it falls Unconscious. If another creature sees it during that window, they raise the alarm. Mercy is riskier than the knife.

Witnesses. A takedown alerts no one unless another creature sees it, hears it, or finds the body.

Once alerted, a creature uses its full stat block for the rest of the mission. Effects that un-alert a creature, like Baffle Dust, make it eligible for a takedown again.

Resilient creatures. Bosses and elite threats, such as a witch matriarch, an Overseer captain, or a Clockwork Soldier, have the **Resilient** tag and can't be taken down. A hidden attack against one still has Advantage and can still trigger Sneak Attack, but it uses normal damage. Mission targets are usually not Resilient: landing the assassination is the payoff.

When Things Go Wrong

Getting discovered should feel frantic and out of control. Some ways to get there:

- **Start combat immediately.** The moment a guard raises the alarm, roll Initiative. No time to regroup.
- **Escalate every round.** While the alarm sounds, the nearest guard group arrives at the end of each round, until the party breaks line of sight.
- **Make hiding the answer.** Escaping and hiding again should usually beat fighting it out. Once the guards lose sight of the party for a few rounds, they search the area, then return to their patrols on alert.
- **It leaves a mark.** A raised alarm adds Chaos if you're using the Chaos Tracker, and an alerted area stays harder for the rest of the mission.

◆

☾

Take a long rest, we'll wake you for the loot.

New subclasses and homebrew every week, free, at longrestpress.com.
If this one earned a spot at your table, you can support the press at ko-fi.com/T1N0299Y80.

LONG REST PRESS · A CLARK CONSOLIDATED LABEL

Inspired by *Dishonored* by Arkane Studios. This is unofficial fan work, not affiliated with or endorsed by Arkane Studios or Bethesda.

Long Rest Press content is unofficial Fan Content permitted under the Fan Content Policy. Not approved/endorsed by Wizards. Portions of the materials used are property of Wizards of the Coast. ©Wizards of the Coast LLC.